

Injured hawk gets second chance



JOHN MANTLE/FORT MILL TIMES

This red tail hawk, injured in a collision with a car in Fort Mill Township, is fighting for its life in Charlotte's Carolina Raptor Center. Volunteers took the bird there after it was rescued from the roadside. (Story and another photo: Page 3A.)

Hawk, wounded in Fort Mill mishap, gets plenty of loving care in Charlotte

By John Mantle
Times Publisher

Battered and bruised, a red tail hawk is fighting for its life after being rescued from a roadside shoulder in Fort Mill Township by passing motorists last week.

The bird is being cared for at the Carolina Raptor Center in northern Charlotte. It was taken to veterinarian Dr. John Lesslie at Fort Mill's Catawba Animal Clinic on Main Street by John Watkins of Rock Hill. A volunteer from the center picked up the bird from Lesslie's office.

A gaping three-inch wound underneath one of the bird's wings was cleaned and bandaged by biologist Mathias Engelmann at the Raptor Center Saturday. Cuts on the bird's toes, possibly from an animal or a barbed wire fence, were also treated.

Engelmann, the center's rehabilitation coordinator, thinks the red tail was hit by a car and then possibly attacked by an animal as it lay helpless on the road shoulder.

"It's too early to tell whether it will be okay or not," he said Saturday. "He's not going to the bathroom as well as he should and that's worrying."

"It could be that he is still weak, or he could have an internal blockage. One good sign is that he is eating well."

The hawk—it has a wingspan of three to four feet—was found by dental hygienist Tess Smith of Rock Hill as she drove down U.S. 21 Bus. in Fort Mill.

It was sitting on the ground by the side of the road with its wings spread out. I could tell it had been hurt. Its mouth was open and its leg was kind of hanging," Smith said.

"I had my children in the car. I didn't want to leave them but I

didn't want to leave the bird either. I was getting ready to get a blanket out of my car and a fellow pulled up and asked if I needed help."

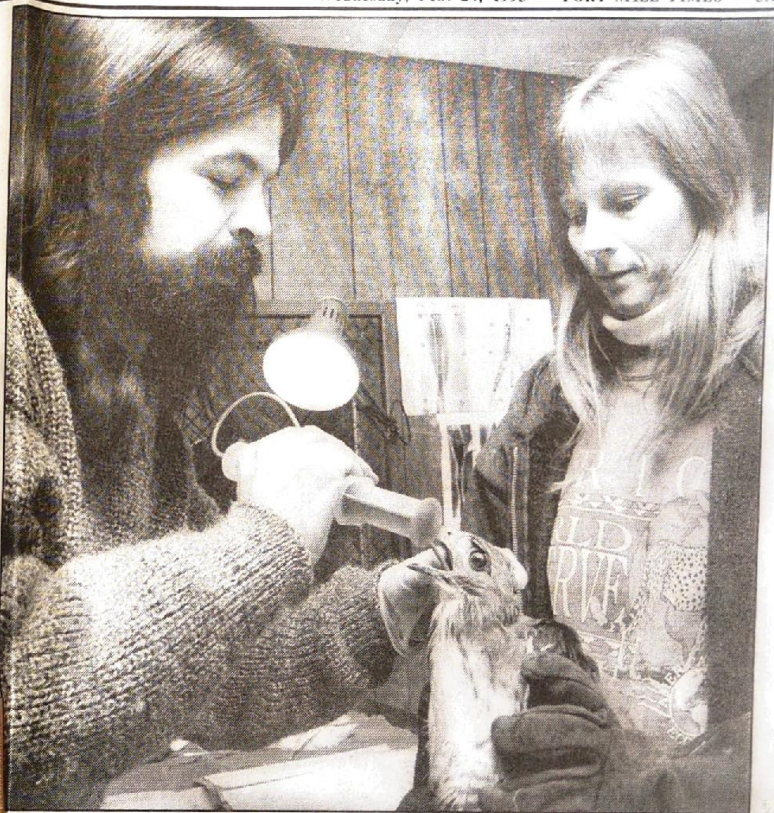
"It flew off down into the woods. He went down after it and wrapped it up in his jacket."

Engelmann fed the hawk some chopped-up mice Saturday and reported that it was gaining weight. The bird had been released from the center just a month ago, he said, after being in another vehicle mishap and suffering a light concussion.

"We know it's the same hawk because we banded it at that time. We have to find out if there's a reason why he is accident prone."

Has he given the bird a name?

"No, it's definitely not good to get too attached to them," explained Engelmann. "Of the hundreds of birds of prey brought here each year, only about 40 percent survive."



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Taking care of a feathered friend

Biologist Mathias Engelmann and his wife Linda help a hawk that was brought to Carolina Raptor Center in northern Charlotte after being hit by a car. Engelmann is the center's rehabilitation coordinator. He says only 40 percent of the hundreds of birds that are brought here each year survive.